

PAUL BURLON

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EDUCATION

M.A. Sociology, Ludwig-Maximilians-Universität München Oct 2025 – present
Focus: quantitative inequality research. Current average: 1.2 (expected 2027)

B.A. Sociology, minor in Applied Computer Science, University of Mannheim Sep 2021 – Jan 2025
Final grade: 1.7 · All methods modules: 1.0
Thesis: *Status Maximization via Marriage: Refugees' Partnership Preferences* (1.7),
supervised by Prof. Henning Hillmann; based on anonymised PARFORM wave-1 data

Exchange semester, Singapore Management University Sep 2023 – Apr 2024
Coursework: Big Data Analytics · Agent-based Modeling · Social Networks · Heuristic Search and Optimisation

German grading scale: 1.0 is the highest grade, 4.0 the lowest passing grade.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Quantitative inequality research, with a focus on wealth inequality, migration and integration, and political and media discourse. My methodological interest is in measuring what has been hard to measure: building new data sources and computational instruments — LLM-based classification, speech recognition on audio corpora, digital behavioural data — for substantive questions.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, MZES — Mannheim Centre for European Social Research Apr 2026 – present
New Data and Methods (remote)

- Developing an LLM-based classification scheme to measure cognitive household labour from web-tracking data of the GESIS Panel.dbd (~700 panellists)
- Built a multi-stage pipeline: URL preprocessing, prompt engineering, batch classification via LLM API
- Quality assurance through gold-standard coding; validation against survey measures; analysis of gender differences in household organisation

Research Assistant, MZES — *PARFORM: Partnership Formation in the Context of Recent Refugee Migration* (ERC / Horizon 2020, Grant No. 864683; PI Kogan) Sep 2023 – Jan 2025

- Wrote and iterated Stata code to clean and back-code the open-ended responses of a three-wave multilingual panel survey of refugee men from Syria and Afghanistan (CAPI/CAWI, $N > 3,400$); corrected the ISO country-coding do-file and codebook
- Implemented the wave-3 vignette module in Unipark/EFS Survey; verified its setup, checked translations across survey languages, carried out questionnaire testing
- Screened and catalogued regional indicators from official statistics (GENESIS/Destatis, INKAR/BBSR) for linkage with the survey data
- Screened waves 1–2 for sparsely populated categories, including bivariate checks, in preparation for data anonymisation
- Literature reviews for project manuscripts: religion, partner choice, labour-market integration

Research Intern, BIK Aschpurwis + Behrens GmbH, Hamburg Feb – Apr 2025

- B2B survey study for TU Dortmund: plausibility checks, coding of open-ended responses, weighting, factor analysis and regression models (R, SPSS)
- Supervision of CATI interviewers; revision of the interviewer evaluation instrument

Research Assistant, GESIS — Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences Jul 2022 – Jun 2023
Survey Design and Methodology, GESIS Panel team

- Supported the planning of a survey wave of the GESIS Panel Plus: questionnaire development, technical pretesting, field phase preparation
- Programmed online surveys in EFS Unipark; produced materials for the panel recruitment campaign
- Contributed to the preparation, documentation, and analysis of survey and digital behavioural data as the panel was extended with a web-tracking component

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Joint Program in Survey Methodology, University of Maryland Fall 2026
 Maryland
 SURV400 (remote)

INDEPENDENT RESEARCH

Tagesschau Broadcast Corpus and Migration Salience Project 2025 – present

- Constructed a full-text corpus of the spoken *Tagesschau um 20 Uhr* (ARD), Germany's most-watched television news programme: 12,522 broadcast days (~3,100 hours), January 1991 to July 2026, transcribed locally with Whisper and validated with automated diagnostics against official broadcast subtitles. No comparable public corpus of the broadcast exists
- Developed a monthly dictionary-based measure of migration salience, benchmarked against hand-coded IFEM InfoMonitor airtime shares, with era-specific vocabularies for pre-2005 decades
- Estimating trivariate vector autoregressions with Granger-causality tests (~400 monthly observations) linking media salience, BAMF asylum statistics, and Politbarometer problem-awareness data

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Burlon, P. (2026). *Creating or Mirroring Concern? Tagesschau Migration Coverage, Asylum Numbers, and the Public Agenda in Germany, 1991–2026*. Poster presented at *Analytical Sociology: Theory and Empirical Applications*, Venice International University, San Servolo, 23–26 November.

AWARDS AND FUNDING

PROMOS Scholarship (BMBF / DAAD) — exchange studies, Singapore 2023
 Management University

METHODS AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

- Programming and software:** Python, R, Stata, SQL, Java, SPSS, Git/GitHub
- Computational methods:** LLM-based text classification, automatic speech recognition (Whisper, local deployment), natural language processing, web scraping, network analysis, agent-based modelling
- Statistical methods:** causal inference, longitudinal and panel analysis, time-series models (VAR, Granger causality), multivariate analysis, factor analysis
- Survey methodology:** questionnaire development, technical pretesting, weighting, EFS Unipark
- Languages:** German (native), English (fluent; TOEFL iBT 109), French (intermediate), Dutch (beginner)

SERVICE AND OTHER EXPERIENCE

Volunteer, L'Arche Toulouse, France Aug 2020 – Aug 2021
 Thirteen-month voluntary service year (IJFD) via EIRENE; support and accompaniment of 13 adults with disabilities